5,The Need for Water Conservancy is by No Means the Rationale for Maintaining the restoration-bureaucratic state

Finally, I must clarify the myth surrounding the "water conservancy issue" (水利问题). Frankly speaking, this is entirely a theoretical illusion conjured out of thin air by certain Western scholars who lack a fundamental understanding of Chinese history. My verdict is unequivocal: the notion that "the practical necessity of water conservancy construction sustained the despotic ***bureaucratic state*** (官僚国家)" is a complete absurdity that fundamentally collapses under the scrutiny of historical logic.

First, the vast majority of water conservancy projects in ancient China fundamentally do not require the concentration of national power for their construction or maintenance. Under the productive force conditions of an agricultural society, it is already quite remarkable if a single water conservancy project can play a major role over an area equivalent to a single Chinese province. Take the Dujiangyan Irrigation System (都江堰) in my hometown for example: this was merely constructed by Li Bing (李冰), the Governor of Shu Commandery (*Shujun Taishou* 蜀郡太守) during the Qin Dynasty, along with his son, leading the local populace. Is the support of a highly centralized bureaucratic state truly necessary for this? There are also the Zhengguo Canal (郑国渠) and the Bai Canal (白渠) in the Guanzhong region (*Guanzhong* 关中); when actual construction began, the labor mobilized was merely that of the Guanzhong Plain. It is fundamentally impossible to argue that a feudal society would lack the capability to construct and maintain them. The Chengdu Plain and the Guanzhong Plain are only so large; even under a feudal system, could they really be fragmented into a dozen political entities? The fact is, as long as one is not completely blind to Chinese history, one should know that the vast majority of famous water conservancy projects in our history were built by local nobles prior to the Qin Dynasty and by local officials after the Qin Dynasty; they absolutely did not necessitate the support of the central government. And these water conservancy projects organized and constructed at the provincial or municipal levels could absolutely be deemed "large-scale" in ancient times. For ordinary commoners, water conservancy facilities were even a concept confined within the scope of a single village (such as a hundred-meter-long irrigation ditch); how much manpower and material resources could that possibly require to mobilize?

Nowadays on the internet, people often like to exaggerate the large-scale armed brawls (械斗) that occurred between villages in the lineage/clan societies (*Zongzu* 宗族) of China (especially in the south) due to conflicts over water resources, in order to show that Chinese people possess martial virtue (*Wude* 武德). However, any level-headed person can point out that the scale of these armed brawls is only "large" when compared to ordinary fistfights; it does not mean that, if viewed as actual military combat, they were truly that shocking. The combined territorial scope of a few villages that frequently participated in such armed brawls would unlikely exceed the fiefdom of an Earl, let alone a Duke (of course, in Europe, the territorial gap between different feudal lords could be vast even if their ranks were the same; this is merely a broad generalization). Not to mention, armed brawls of this scale were also the product of the massive population growth and the intensification of the imbalance in the ***land-labor ratio*** (人地矛盾) after China was drawn into the early modern world; they were not events that occurred during the stage of feudal society. (I did not express myself clearly here; what I actually mean to say is that the need for water conservancy construction in ancient China—specifically the need for a unified government's intervention—has been severely exaggerated.)

This implies that the vast majority of water conservancy projects that appeared in Chinese history posed no insurmountable obstacles for a feudal society in terms of manpower, material resources, and financial power. Furthermore, a feudal lord's willingness to develop the economy of his own fiefdom is significantly higher than that of a rotating official (*Liuguan* 流官) to earnestly govern his jurisdiction. What reason is there to believe that the former would not do a better job in water conservancy? (In fact, this point is quite obvious. As long as one travels in China for a while, basically anyone who isn't a fool can see that most ancient Chinese water conservancy projects that benefited agriculture and the people—such as the Mulan Weir (木兰陂) in Putian, Fujian—were primarily built by the ***Xiangshen*** (local scholar-elites / 地方士绅). With at most the assistance of the local government, they were entirely sufficient to complete the construction.)

Even in the China of our timeline (本位面), there is no shortage of examples where *feudalized* regional military governors (*Fanzhen* 藩镇) made outstanding contributions to water conservancy construction. For instance, the construction of the Qiantang River seawall by Qian Liu, the King of Wuyue (吴越王钱镠), who evolved from a late-Tang Military Commissioner (*Jiedushi* 节度使), is extremely famous, and the beautiful legend of "King Qian Shooting the Tide" (钱王射潮) survives to this day.

On a global scale, people can equally easily name some world-renowned ancient water conservancy projects that were built and played major roles under low-technology conditions (not even reaching the level of the feudal era) without relying on a large centralized state. These include the Marib Dam (马里卜大坝) in Yemen, the nearby Aflaj Irrigation Systems (法拉吉灌溉系统) in Oman, and Tenochtitlan (特诺奇蒂特兰), built by the Aztecs of the New World on an artificial island in Lake Texcoco, among others. The Maya were equally able to establish water resource management systems in the low-lying regions of northern Yucatán that lacked lakes and rivers, and they hardly even used metal tools.

The fact is, in agricultural societies prior to the Industrial Revolution, there was practically no demand whatsoever to construct colossal water conservancy projects that spanned multiple geographical units and functioned over an even vaster area. A feudal state was entirely capable of handling the water conservancy construction within its own borders.

Second, to reiterate an earlier point, one cannot demand that a feudal society fulfill needs that only exist within a bureaucratic state. A mega-project spanning the entire country like the Grand Canal (大运河) was originally designed to serve the centralized capital of the bureaucratic state; the significance of this canal in extracting the nation's wealth far outweighed its commercial significance for north-south transportation. China's massive grain transport system (*Caoyun* 漕运) began with the needs of military expansion during the reign of Emperor Wu of Han (汉武帝). At that time, grain from the Guandong (关东) region was transported upstream via the Yellow River, crossing an entire geographical step, and was then shipped to the capital via the transport canal connecting Chang'an (长安) and the Yellow River. If China had undergone a normal ***feudalization*** (封建化) process, this demand would naturally have vanished. The Lingqu Canal (灵渠) is another highly typical example. This type of mega-project, utilized by classical states to facilitate large-scale conquests, emerged in a specific historical period; however, in the early and middle stages of a feudal society, the demand to construct it would fundamentally not exist. When the capital of the Roman Empire was still in Rome, the wealth of the entire Mediterranean world flowed towards Rome, but by the year 1000 CE, it was impossible for this to still be the case.

The floods of the Yellow River were likewise a man-made disaster caused by the bureaucratic state. The Yellow River—an important river whose basin is almost entirely located within ***Handi*** (China Proper / 汉地)—indeed generated a relatively significant need for flood control due to its heavy silt content. However, this basic fact has been reduced to a smokescreen used by the bureaucratic state to cover up its incompetence and misdeeds. For nearly 1,000 years after Wang Jing (王景) tamed the Yellow River during the Eastern Han Dynasty, the river experienced no major breaches. Breaches began to appear again from the first half of the 11th century CE. Initially, they did not cause much actual damage. However, in 1048, the Yellow River breached again at Shanghusao (商胡埽). The result of this flooding was the formation of two branches in the lower reaches of the Yellow River: the branch known as the "Eastern Flow" (东流) at least remained within the territory of the Song Dynasty, but the "Northern Flow" (北流) surged all the way north into the final stretch of the Haihe River (海河), emptying into the sea at the border between the Song and the Liao (辽) dynasties.

The Song court felt anxious about this because, having failed to recover the crucial barrier of the Yanshan Mountains (燕山), the entire North China Plain was left in a defenseless state. The only geographical barrier that could afford the Song rulers any psychological sense of security was nothing other than the Yellow River. Now that the Yellow River was flowing further north, the decision-makers of the Song Empire believed their defensive system in the north had been compromised. For a bloated bureaucratic state, rather than expecting itself to adjust its rigid national defense strategy, it was simpler to just try blocking the Northern Flow altogether. Thus, during the reigns of Emperors Renzong (仁宗), Shenzong (神宗), and Zhezong (哲宗), the Northern Song court attempted three times to forcibly block the Northern Flow. Not only did they expend immense manpower and material resources without success, but each attempt also resulted in breaches that brought catastrophic loss of life and property to the people.

During the Song-Jin Wars, Song military commanders, in order to rely on the water's momentum to stop the Jin (金) troops from advancing south, deliberately breached the Yellow River dikes, causing the river to change course southward. This formed a long-term situation where the Yellow River seized the path of the Huai River to enter the sea (夺淮入海). By the end of the 12th century, the Northern Flow was completely cut off. When the Mongol army (蒙古军队) marched south in 1234, they once again utilized the Yellow River to stage the "spectacle" of using water as a substitute for soldiers through artificial breaching.

Since the Yellow River flowed south and seized the Huai, it remained extremely unstable. Although, generally speaking, it ultimately emptied into the sea from the estuary of the Huai River, it was hard to say exactly where it split into several branches to enter the Huai River channel, because a single breach could alter its course once again. It was not until Pan Jixun (潘季驯) tamed the Yellow River in the late Ming Dynasty that the southern flow was fixed in place for 300 years. However, ever since the Yellow River long-termly seized the Huai River to enter the sea, floods of the Yellow River became extremely frequent, bringing incalculable harm to the people of the Yellow and Huai river regions.

The continuous and severe flooding caused by the Yellow River's southward invasion into the Huai River basin possessed an element of inevitability. Throughout most of its recorded history, the Yellow River had entered the sea via the North China Plain; its long-term southward flow was originally an abnormal phenomenon caused by human intervention. Viewed solely from the perspective of water resource distribution, it was also highly irrational: the North China Plain was already more deficient in water compared to the Huai River basin. The southward flow deprived an initially water-deficient region of a major river, while forcing the relatively well-watered Huai River (and its tributaries) to bear the extra water volume of the entire Yellow River using its original channels. It would have been a miracle if this did not render the river defenses highly precarious.

The Yangtze-Huai River basin natively experiences the "plum rain" season (梅雨季); during June and July, there are often continuous, uninterrupted rains lasting for dozens of days. The *Huai'an Fu Zhi* (Gazetteer of Huai'an Prefecture) [淮安府志], compiled during the Qianlong era (乾隆年) of the Qing Dynasty, records: *"Since the mid-Ming Dynasty, whenever the Huai River swells, the west wind whips up the waves, and the white crests tower like mountains. Across the hundreds of li (里) of Huai'an and Yangzhou, both public officials and private citizens are in a state of terror, and no one dares to sleep peacefully. This has been the case for hundreds of years"* (自明中叶以来，每淮水盛时，西风激浪，白波如山，淮扬数百里，公私惶惶，莫敢安枕者，数百年矣). This vividly illustrates the immense pressure on river defenses during the flood season each year.

Yet, if this was the case, why not allow the Yellow River to revert to its northern flow? In fact, before it finally changed course and once again emptied into the Bohai Sea (渤海) in 1855, the Yellow River naturally breached its dikes northward and re-emerged with northern branches several times during the Yuan, Ming, and Qing dynasties. However, the reaction of the imperial court was invariably and resolutely to block the northern flow to death.

This question is precisely the key to understanding the floods of the Yellow River in China. The answer is: although the southward flow of the Yellow River would cause the deaths of millions, if not tens of millions of commoners, it was advantageous for the grain transport system (*Caoyun* 漕运) destined for the capital, Beijing (北京). This was because the Yellow River—already carrying a heavy load of silt—frequently changed its course across the flat terrain of the North China Plain. Consequently, the channels of the Yellow River on the North China Plain were extremely shallow, later even turning into an "elevated river" (地上悬河) flowing above the surrounding ground. If the Grand Canal intersected the Yellow River at this location, it would be extremely easy for the canal to become clogged with silt and rendered unusable in a very short period.

If we observe the Sui-Tang Grand Canal (隋唐大运河) along the Yellow River from west to east, it is not difficult to discover that the Yongji Canal (永济渠) extending northeast to Zhuojun (涿郡) and the Tongji Canal (通济渠) extending southeast to Xuyi (盱眙) looked like two branches extending outward from the junction of the middle and lower reaches of the Yellow River. In other words, the location where the Sui-Tang Grand Canal intersected with the Yellow River deliberately avoided the downstream region on the North China Plain where the river channels were shallower.

Later, after the Yellow River restored its northern flow in 1855—namely, emptying into the sea along its present course—the Qing government installed ship locks at the intersection of the Yellow River and the northern end of the canal for navigation. However, true to expectations, the canal was very quickly choked with silt until it was unusable. By that time, Western science and technology had been introduced, and the efficiency of maritime transport had thoroughly crushed inland river navigation. Successive governments no longer attempted to restore the canal's passage across the Yellow River; even today, the Beijing-Hangzhou Grand Canal (京杭大运河) remains disconnected where it approaches the Yellow River.

Presently, with the assistance of modern science and technology, China's South-to-North Water Diversion Project (南水北调工程) has been able to allow the diverted water to pass *beneath* the riverbed of the Yellow River (which is already an elevated river)—this is what the Chinese government refers to as the "River-Crossing Project" (穿黄工程). However, let alone attempting to make the Grand Canal cross the Yellow River again (even if just for tourism purposes), not even the lower reaches of the Yellow River have achieved navigability. Therefore, if the Yellow River did not flow south, even if the Chinese empire later moved its capital to Beijing rather than residing in Chang'an or Luoyang, to construct a canal from Jiangnan (江南) to Beijing, they would probably still have had to conform to the shape of the Sui-Tang Grand Canal.

However, a dramatic turn of events occurred: the Yellow River usurped the path of the Huai River and entered the sea southward. Although making the Yellow River flow south was initially clearly not intended for the grain transport system (*Caoyun* 漕运), but was merely a clumsy blunder by the Song people, the imperial court soon realized a crucial point. The Yellow River's change of course made it possible for the canal to cross the lower reaches of the Yellow River, thereby providing the precondition for the straightening and shortening of the Beijing-Hangzhou Grand Canal (京杭大运河).

This was because, although the runoff volume of the Huai River was somewhat smaller than that of the Yellow River, over a long period, the channel of the Huai River remained quite stable, and the Huai River itself carried a small amount of silt. Therefore, the riverbed of the Huai River had been scoured relatively deep. When the massive water volume of the Yellow River poured in, the distance from the riverbed to the water's surface became even deeper. Under these conditions, the Grand Canal could naturally cross the Yellow River without impacting grain transport. This is why, despite the massive disasters the Yellow River's southward flow brought to the commoners on both banks, the imperial court consistently viewed it as a benefit, terrified lest the Yellow River flow north again.

In fact, we must point out that, as long as no threat is posed to its existence, a bureaucratic state absolutely does not care about the life or death of commoners living thousands of *li* away from the capital. The southward flow of the Yellow River indeed likely exacerbated droughts in Zhili (直隶) and Shandong (山东), leaving the commoners living along the Yellow and Huai rivers under the constant threat of death year after year. But what did this matter to the emperor and the bureaucrats in Beijing? In their eyes, how could the lives of a few million commoners possibly be more important than the grain and wealth transported to Beijing? If we search through the historical materials of the Ming and Qing dynasties, it is not difficult to notice that when there are records of Yellow-Huai flooding, the importance of grain transport is placed far ahead of the lives of the people. In many cases, there are only records of "damage to the transport canal" (坏漕渠); exactly what kind of losses the commoners suffered goes completely unrecorded.

If people harbor any doubts regarding the attitude adopted by the Chinese empire in managing the Yellow River, my suggestion is to directly read Chapters 59 and 60 of the *Ming Shi* (History of Ming) [明史]. These two sections belong precisely to the *Treatise on the Yellow River* (黄河志), and the kinds of interest calculations the imperial court engaged in are manifested with crystal clarity therein. For example, in Chapter 59, the remonstrance of Tu Sheng (涂升), an Investigating Censor in Henan, states it very plainly: *"When the Yellow River causes a disaster, a southern breach afflicts Henan, and a northern breach afflicts Shandong. In the past, during the Han Dynasty, it breached at Suanzao and again at Huzi; during the Song Dynasty, it breached at Guantao and again at Chanzhou; during the Yuan Dynasty, it breached at Bianliang and again at Pukou. However, because the Han capital was in Guanzhong and the Song capital was in Daliang, the disaster caused by a river breach only affected a few commanderies bordering the river. Today, the capital relies entirely on the Huitong Canal for the annual transport of millions of shi of grain; if the river breaches to the north, it will become a massive worry for grain transport"* (黄河为患，南决病河南，北决病山东。昔汉决酸枣，复决瓠子；宋决馆陶，复决澶州；元决汴梁，复决蒲口。然汉都关中，宋都大梁，河决为患，不过濒河数郡而已。今京师专藉会通河岁漕粟数百万石，河决而北，则大为漕忧). Whether the Yellow River breached south or north, how many commoners died was a trivial matter; the urgent priority was that the Yellow River must not be allowed to flow north, for then grain transport would become a problem.

That a northern flow of the Yellow River was beneficial for the stability of the river channel and advantageous for the commoners of the realm was never a secret in China; the rulers and the high-level intellectuals knew this perfectly well in their hearts. Hu Wei (胡渭), an expert in classical studies (*Jingxuejia* 经学家) and geographer of the early Qing Dynasty, recorded the commentary of the Yuan Dynasty official Yu Que (余阙) in the second half of Chapter 13 of his work *Yugong Zhuizhi* (A Pointed Investigation of the Tribute of Yu) [禹贡锥指]: *"[Yu Que] said: The land in the south is originally higher than in the north; thus, moving the river south is difficult, while moving it north is easy... Why must we exhaust labor and wealth year after year to prevent a northern breach?"* (余阙曰：南方之地本高于北，河之南徙难而北徒易…奚必歲歲劳费防其北决邪？). One must realize that at that time, the Beijing-Hangzhou Grand Canal had only been fully connected for a few years in total. Even Baidu Baike (百度百科), which has always been notorious in China for its poor quality of information, straightforwardly admits that the so-called water disasters of the Yuan, Ming, and Qing dynasties were fundamentally a political disaster that persisted for six centuries, rather than something that could be shirked off as natural disasters.

In the eyes of the officials responsible for river affairs, the commoners on both banks were naturally not worth mentioning compared to grain transport. For example, Pan Jixun (潘季驯), the famous water management official of the Ming Dynasty, once said, *"It is a situation of mutual causality: if the Huai is afflicted, then the Yellow River is afflicted; if the Yellow River is afflicted, then the grain transport is also afflicted"* (是淮病而黄病，黄病而漕亦病，相因之势也). As for the "affliction of the commoners," it was simply omitted. One absolutely cannot blame Pan Jixun for saying this. Chinese people always possess an inexplicable filter regarding so-called "virtuous officials" and "capable ministers." In reality, however, as long as they are bureaucrats, their power derives from their superiors, so they must inevitably be responsible to their superiors. On this point, there will be absolutely no difference between Yan Song (严嵩) and Hai Rui (海瑞). The ones who held the fate of the river affairs officials in their hands were the emperors, not the commoners on the two banks; therefore, they had no choice but to place the grain transport upon which the emperor relied ahead of the life and death of the commoners.

A fact that might profoundly shock foreigners is that, despite our country repeatedly trumpeting the "great significance" of the Grand Canal at the official level—constructing numerous museums themed around it nationwide, alongside top-tier (5A) tourist attractions centered on its landscapes, and even successfully registering it as a UNESCO World Heritage site in 2014—the cruel essence of the Grand Canal as a "river of blood and tears" is hardly a secret, even in mainland China today.

Not only can the official histories, such as the *Yuan Shi* (History of Yuan) [元史] and the *Ming Shi* (History of Ming) [明史], be publicly accessed, but important academic works relating to China's history of water conservancy—which directly point out that the floods of the Yellow River during the late Chinese Empire were primarily man-made political disasters—are also not banned books. For instance, the *Huanghe Bianqian Shi* (History of the Transformations of the Yellow River) [黄河变迁史], authored by the Chinese historian Cen Zhongmian (岑仲勉) in the last century, remains available.

Tianxia Changhe (The Long River) [天下长河], a 2022 mainland Chinese television drama praising the water management achievements during the reign of the Kangxi Emperor (康熙) of the Qing Dynasty, features a highly thought-provoking scene: Emperor Kangxi looks at three pieces of paper posted on the wall, each inscribed with an affair of state that weighs heavily on his mind. The paper in the middle reads "Grain Transport" (*Caoyun* 漕运), the paper on the left reads "River Affairs" (*Hewu* 河务), and the paper on the right reads "The Three Feudatories" (*Sanfan* 三藩). The order in which these three pieces of paper are arranged perfectly reflects the degree of importance of these three matters in the eyes of Emperor Kangxi. It hints even more dramatically at one point: when the empire always prioritizes grain transport over river affairs, it is forever impossible to make the Yellow River run clear and the seas calm. We cannot know whether this scene was intentionally crafted by the drama's director and screenwriters, but it obviously reflects that, even today, there are plenty of Chinese intellectuals who clearly understand the true essence of the so-called "management of the Yellow River" in the late Chinese Empire.

Therefore, the assertion that the need for flood control was the driving factor for the state to strengthen the bureaucratic system is an argument with its cause and effect completely inverted. We should straightforwardly point out that it is precisely the bureaucratic state's utter disregard for human life, its absolute obedience to superiors, its corrupt incompetence, and its grandiose posturing (好大喜功) that artificially magnified the various so-called "natural disasters" across the Chinese land. The Banqiao Dam Failure (板桥水库溃决) of 1975 is a relatively recent, typical example of this. Thus, there is absolutely no such thing as "water conservancy forging the empire." Quite the contrary: it was precisely to maintain the already existing ***restoration-bureaucratic empire*** (复辟官僚帝国) that the entire Chinese society was forced to inject such staggering investments into water conservancy and sacrifice so much in vain.

Returning to the Yellow River: it is highly ironic that, because the silt content of the Yellow River was truly so massive, on the eve of China being forced to open its doors, even the riverbed of the Huai River had already been drastically elevated by sediment deposition. By the Qing Dynasty, in order to allow boats on the Grand Canal to normally cross the Yellow River, people had no choice but to construct increasingly complex auxiliary channels at the junction of the two. Looking at it on a map, it resembled nothing so much as a heart densely propped up by scaffolding. Yet, even so, it merely treated the symptoms and not the disease; by the end of the Qianlong reign, it was only a matter of time before the southward-flowing Yellow River choked the canal's navigation. Instead, it was the science and technology brought by Western ironclads and cannons that finally liberated the Chinese people from this "Canal Prison" (运河监狱).

The so-called water conservancy enterprises of the late Chinese Empire were, in essence, merely a microcosm of a behemoth with feet of clay—trapped in a dead end—struggling day after day toward its own demise. The entire system did not hesitate to force the people to pay any sacrifice, solely to remain stable on its original track for a few more days, but ultimately, it could not ensure its longevity and was doomed to perish. If one contemplates the following hypothesis—namely, if China had continually avoided contact with the West, where would it have headed during the late Qing Dynasty under the circumstances of an ecological collapse in the north and the canal completely losing its function? Could Beijing have still served as the capital of an autocratic empire? I believe the answer to this would be extremely intriguing.

Third, as emphasized previously, without the suppression of the bureaucratic state, China's process of ***feudalization*** (封建化) naturally would not have stalled at the primary stage but would have continued to develop. Therefore, we cannot assume that a *feudalized* China would permanently possess only the public works construction capacity of the Early Middle Ages. Looking at the situation in Europe, starting from the High Middle Ages, feudal states already possessed the capability to construct large-scale public works. Even regarding water conservancy projects, there is the example of the Netherlands region constructing massive seawalls starting from the 10th century.

The power that an ***early modern society*** (近世社会) could mobilize after the end of the feudal period was even more formidable. On a global scale, perhaps the most representative example is the construction of Edo by the Tokugawa Shogunate (*Tokugawa Bakufu* 德川幕府). The shogunate thoroughly tamed the raging rivers on the Kanto Plain and, in just a century, transformed Edo into the largest city in the world. Such an achievement was made, moreover, in a narrow, isolationist island nation. During the same period, Absolutist Europe was also experiencing a time when water conservancy projects were in full swing, and the completion of numerous canals serves as powerful proof.

If China's ***feudalization*** had continued normally, estimating from the fact that our country's ***feudalization*** began relatively early (the trend of ***feudalization*** was already highly apparent by the late Eastern Han Dynasty), a feudal China would have ended its typical feudal class society and begun transitioning into an ***early modern state*** (近世国家) by the time of the Yuan Dynasty in our timeline (本位面) at the latest—which is exactly when the current Beijing-Hangzhou Grand Canal was built. Therefore, we have every reason to believe that if an early modern China, having undergone the process of ***feudalization***, wanted to construct the Beijing-Hangzhou Grand Canal of the Yuan, Ming, and Qing dynasties, it would absolutely not have lacked the power to do so—and could even have done it much better.

Fourth, even if there exists a massive demand for construction in flood control and water conservancy projects, whether this would inevitably produce a stable bureaucratic order like that of China remains questionable. In the tropical regions further south than China, there are no relatively distinct four seasons as there are in China's ***Zhongyuan*** (The Central Plains / 中原); instead, there is only the distinction between wet and dry seasons. The manifestations of floods and droughts are far more extreme. There is no reason to believe that the demand for large-scale public water conservancy facilities in these regions was any smaller than in China.

For example, we can clearly point out that the Khmer Empire (高棉帝国), which was in the ***classical period*** (古典时期), obviously relied heavily on water conservancy projects. This is highly evident from the number of large-scale reservoirs near Angkor. However, the God-Kings of Khmer accomplished this by integrating water conservancy construction into the sacred aura generated by massive religious architectural complexes. As for Khmer's own ***classical bureaucratic system*** (古典官僚体制), it was pathetically weak. This empire did not even have a decent law of succession; out of a total of twenty-six God-Kings, only eight inherited the throne from their brothers or fathers.

Medieval India likewise relied on the power of religion when carrying out large-scale water conservancy construction. The magnificent stepwells (阶梯井) widely found across India are powerful proof. From a practical standpoint, although stepwells were used to store water sources during the dry season, the religious atmosphere expressed by their colossal scale and exquisite sculptural art would undoubtedly leave believers awestruck.

In the vast Islamic world across the Eurasian continent, an arid or semi-arid environment is the norm of life. The local agriculture's reliance on irrigation is obviously something that the regions inside China's Great Wall (长城以内)—with an average annual precipitation of over 400 millimeters—simply cannot compare to. However, one can clearly see that even though medieval Muslim monarchs were visibly more autocratic than their European counterparts, compared to the emperors of China, their autocracy was simply child's play. This is because Islamic society accomplished social organization in various settlements centered around mosques through the clerical class. The clerics played a leading and arbitrating role in the construction and maintenance of water conservancy facilities, as well as the distribution and use of water resources. By exerting this function, they conversely further consolidated their social status; therefore, the entire society fundamentally did not need a tremendously powerful bureaucratic system.

If one notes modern Iran, currently ruled by a theocratic government where religion and state are unified, it is precisely a civilization of antiquity that is overall highly arid, possesses an extremely long history of irrigation agriculture, and currently follows the Islamic faith. Therefore, through such observation, it is not difficult to draw a conclusion: even if a regime or civilization from the ***classical period*** to the Middle Ages possessed a highly intense practical need to construct large-scale public water facilities, its reaction would most likely be to seek assistance from religion (of course, this does not rule out its political need for centralization; it is just that history outside of China demonstrates that cooperation between a feudal regime and religious organizations was entirely adequate for the needs of water conservancy construction and maintenance in that era).

If we recall the reaction of Emperor Wu of Han (汉武帝) when facing severe floods, it is easy to remember that even the Chinese empire of that era relied on the assistance of religion. Whether it was counting on the magic of the *fangshi* (esoteric practitioners / 方士) to quell the floods, or erecting palaces at the breach of the Yellow River to suppress the disaster, these were fundamentally religious acts. It was merely that the formidable state capacity of the Han Empire meant it no longer needed religion to issue a rallying cry when taking concrete actions to resolve the floods (though it was not entirely unneeded; for example, right before Emperor Wu personally went to Huzi (瓠子) to command the blocking of the Yellow River breach, he had just returned from completing the Fengshan sacrifices at Mount Tai (泰山封禅), which in itself generated a religious aura).

Moreover, in regions outside of China, one can indeed point out certain highly autocratic and centralized ancient regimes that constructed massive water conservancy projects under the will and organization of the government, such as Ancient Egypt and the Inca Empire. However, upon careful reflection, one discovers that these regimes inherently relied heavily on the inspirational power of religion. The Pharaohs not only possessed divinity themselves but also cooperated with the priests, while the Inca royal family simply claimed to be the descendants of the Sun God.

We must point out that "de-religionization" (去宗教化) itself is a prominent characteristic of the Chinese empire since the bureaucratic restoration. This point is reflected in all aspects of society, ranging from the decline of religious organizations in China's interior to the shifts in the sources of regime legitimacy. The dramatic decline in the influence of religion on social construction was originally a highly crucial cross-section of what academia calls the "Tang-Song Transition" (唐宋变革); it was the inevitable outcome brought about during the formation and consolidation of the ***restoration-bureaucratic state***. The bureaucratic system of the restored Chinese empire harbored an extreme hatred for religions competing with it for local control; otherwise, the persecutions of Buddhism by the Three Wus and One Zong (三武一宗灭佛) would never have occurred. Therefore, during the timeframe when *feudal relations of production* (封建生产关系) functioned as the mainstream, it is hard to say there was any strong causal relationship between the massive demand to construct large-scale public water facilities and the formation and maintenance of a powerful bureaucratic system. This theory is absurd.

Thus, to my own surprise, I have used such a massive amount of space to complete a matter that I initially thought would only require a brief explanation to be accomplished. But writing more has its benefits: I have now thoroughly refuted the two primary theories the current academic community uses to defend the ***bureaucratic system of China's restoration period***. As for the rest, they are not even worth refuting. Writing in greater detail is precisely what ought to be done, so long as it can drive the final nail into the coffin of this demon that has ravaged for 14 centuries.

以下为中文原文:

5，水利需求绝非复辟官僚国家维持的理由

最后，我必须澄清所谓“水利问题”的迷思。坦率地说，这完全是部分对中国历史缺乏底层认知的西方学者凭空臆造的理论幻象。我的论断非常明确：认为“水利建设的现实需求维系了专制主义官僚国家”的观点，在历史逻辑上是根本站不住脚的荒谬之论。

第一，古代中国大部分水利工程根本不需要什么集中全国力量进行修建或者维护，以农业社会的生产力条件，一个水利工程能够对中国一个省的面积起到重大作用那就已经很了不起了。就拿我老家都江堰的都江堰水利工程来说，这也就是秦代蜀郡太守李冰父子带领当地

百姓修建的，有必要一个中央集权官僚国家进行支撑吗？还有关中的郑国渠，白渠，真正动工的时候调动的也就是关中平原的人力，根本不可能说封建社会就没有能力进行修建和维护。成都平原和关中平原就那么大，哪怕是封建制度下，难道还能分裂成十几个政治实体不成？事实就是只要不是对中国历史两眼一抹黑，就应该知道我国历史上有名的水利工程大多数都是秦之前的地方贵族以及秦之后的地方官员所修建的，不是非要中央政府的支持。而这些由省、市一级组织修建的水利工程在古代已经绝对称得上大型了，对于平常百姓来说水利设施甚至是一个村庄范围内的概念（比如百十米长的灌溉渠），它能需要动用多少人力物力？

现在互联网上往往喜欢夸大中国（尤其是南方）宗族社会的村落之间因为争夺水资源这样的矛盾出现大规模的械斗，以显示中国人具有武德。但是任何人冷静的人都能指出的是，械斗的规模大是和一般的打架斗殴相比，并不是说它如果被视为战斗真的就有多骇人听闻。时常参与械斗的几个村庄，其范围加起来都不太可能超过一个伯爵的领地，更不要说一位公爵了（当然在欧洲不同封建领主之间哪怕级别相同领地差距也可以很大，这只是泛泛而谈）。更不要说这种规模的械斗也属于中国被卷入近代世界之后，人口大幅增长人地矛盾加剧的产物，不属于封建社会阶段发生的事件。（这里我表达得不清楚，其实我想说的是，中国古代水利工程建设的需要，特别是统一政府介入的需要被严重夸大了）

这就意味着中国历史上出现过的绝大多数水利工程，对于封建社会而言都没有什么人力，物力和财力上的不可克服之处，而且封建领主对于发展自己领地经济的意愿显著高于流官去认真治理自己的辖地，有什么理由认为前者不会在水利方面做得更好？（其实这一点很显然，只要在中国旅行一段时间，基本上不傻的人都能看出来中国古代的大部分利农利民的水利工程，例如福建莆田木兰陂，主要靠地方士绅，充其量在地方官府的帮助下足够修建完成了）哪怕本位面的中国也不乏封建化的藩镇军阀对水利建设做出杰出贡献的例子，例如从唐末节度使演变而来的吴越王钱镠修建钱塘江海堤的事情就极为著名，至今尚有“钱王射潮”的美谈。在全世界范围内人们一样可以轻易说出一些闻名遐迩的古代水利工程，他们低技术条件下（甚至连封建时代的水平也达不到）不依靠大型中央集权国家就得以建成并发挥了重要作用，包括也门的马里卜大坝（Marib Dam）和旁边阿曼的法拉吉灌溉系统（Aflaj Irrigation Systems），还有新大陆阿兹特克人在特斯科科湖中的人工岛上建立的特诺奇蒂特兰（Tenochtitlan）等等。玛雅人在尤卡坦北部缺少湖泊和河流的低级地区一样，能建立水资源管理系统，他们也不怎么使用金属工具。事实就是，工业革命之前的农业社会几乎就不存在修建横跨数个地理单元并且在更大范围内起到作用的超大水利工程的需求，封建国家完全可以应付自己国内的水利建设。

第二，还是那句话，你不能要求封建社会去解决只有官僚国家才存在的需求。像大运河这样贯穿全国的超级工程原本就是为官僚国家的集权首都服务的，这条运河对于全国财富进行汲取的意义远大于其南北交通的商业意义。中国大规模的漕运始于汉武帝时期军事扩张的

需要，当时关东的粮食通过黄河向上游运输跨过一整个地理阶梯，然后再经联通长安与黄河的漕渠运到首都。如果中国经历了正常的封建化进程，这种需求自然也就消失了。灵渠是另一个很典型的例子，这种古典国家用来协助大范围征服事业的超级工程产生于特定历史时期，但是如果是在封建社会的中前期根本不存在修建它的需求。罗马帝国首都还在罗马的时候整个地中海世界的财富都流向罗马，但是公元 1000 年的时候就不可能还这样了。

黄河水患同样是官僚国家导致的人祸，黄河作为流域绝大部分都在汉地的重要河流因其含沙量大确实形成了比较大的水患治理需求，然而这个基本事实却沦为了官僚国家掩盖其无能和恶行的烟幕弹。自从东汉王景治理黄河之后近 1000 年间黄河没有大的决溢，从公元十一世纪上半叶开始再次出现决口，最开始并没有造成多少实际上的损失，然而，在 1048 年黄河再次在商胡埽决口，这次泛滥之后的结果是使黄河下游形成两支，其中被称为“东流”那一支至少还在宋朝境内，但是“北流”已经一路向北冲到海河的最后一段河道于宋辽边境入海。宋朝朝廷对此感到担忧，因为未能收复燕山这一重要屏障，整个华北平原都处于一种无险可守的状态，唯一能让宋朝统治者获得心理上安全感的地理屏障无非黄河而已。现在黄河向更北的方向流去，是宋帝国的决策者认为自己在北方的防御体系受到了破坏，而对于一个臃肿的官僚国家来说，指望自己能够调整僵化的国防战略，还不如干脆试着把北流堵上。于是在仁宗，神宗和哲宗年间北宋朝廷三次试图强行堵塞北流，不但耗费了巨大的人力物力，也未获得成功，而且次次造成决口给人民带来极大生命和财产损失。在宋金战争期间，宋军将领为靠水势阻挡金兵南下，主动掘开黄河堤防造成黄河向南改道，形成了长期夺淮入海的局面。到 12 世纪末，北流断绝，1234 年蒙古军队南下时又利用黄河上演了以水代兵人为决堤的“好戏”。黄河南流夺淮以来极不稳定，虽然整体上讲总归是从淮河的河口入海，但是具体从哪里分为几支流入淮河河道那就难说了，因为决口一次就可能改变一次，直到明朝后期潘季驯治理黄河才把南流固定下来 300 年之久。然而，自从黄河长期夺淮入海，黄河水患变得极其频繁，给黄淮地区的人民带来了不可估量的伤害。

黄河南侵淮河流域造成持续严重的水患有其必然性，因为黄河在有历史记载以来大部分时间都经过华北平原入海，长期南流本来就是人力导致的异常现象。单从水资源分布上看，也十分不合理，华北平原较于淮河流域本就缺水，而南流就使得原本相对缺水的地方少了一条大河，原本相对就不缺水的淮河（以及淮河的支流）反而还要以原有的河道多承载一个黄河的水量，这不令河防岌岌可危就怪了。江淮流域本就存在梅雨季，在六，七月份常常几十天连阴雨不断，清代乾隆年所修的《淮安府志》写道，“自明中叶以来，每淮水盛时，西风激浪，白波如山，淮扬数百里，公私惶惶，莫敢安枕者，数百年矣。”足可见每年汛期河防压力之大。可是既然如此，为什么不令黄河复北流呢？事实上，直到 1855 年改道重新注入渤海之前，元明清三代黄河当然也有数次向北决堤重新出现北流分支，但是朝廷的反应一定是坚决地将北流堵死。

这个问题就是看待中国黄河水患的关键，回答是，黄河南流虽然会让老百姓死上几百几千万，但是对于以首都北京为目的地的漕运是有利的。这是由于本就含沙量大的黄河在地势平坦的华北平原频繁改道，因此华北平原上的黄河河道是很浅的，到后来甚至变成地上悬河，一旦大运河在这个位置与黄河相交，那么就极容易被泥沙在短时间内堵塞至无法使用。如果我们沿着黄河从西向东观察隋唐大运河，就不难发现向东北延伸至涿郡的永济渠和向东南延伸到盱眙的通济渠就像是从黄河中游和下游交接处伸出的两个分叉，也就是说隋唐大运河和黄河相交的位置避开了华北平原上河道较浅的下游地区。后来在 1855 年黄河重新恢复北流即沿现在的河道入海后，清政府虽然在黄河与运河北端的相交处设置了船闸进行通航，但是果不其然很快运河就堵塞到无法使用了。而当时西方科学技术传入，海运的效率已经彻底压倒了内河航运，历代政府也不再试图让运河恢复穿过黄河，直到今天京杭大运河在与黄河接近处仍然是断开的。现在在现代科学技术的帮助下，中国的南水北调工程已经可以让所调之水穿过黄河河床（已经是地上悬河了）下方（这就是中国政府所说的穿黄工程），但是不要说重新让大运河穿过黄河（作为旅游的意义），就是黄河下游也没有实现通航。所以说假使黄河不南流，即使中华帝国在后来迁都到北京而不是坐镇长安洛阳，要想修建一条从江南到北京的运河，恐怕还是得按隋唐大运河的那个形状来。

然而戏剧性的事情发生了，那就是黄河向南夺淮入海。虽然让黄河南流最初显然不是为了漕运而不过是宋人的拙劣行为，但是朝廷很快就意识到了一个关键之处，那就是黄河改道使得运河穿过下游黄河变得可能，从而为截弯取直的京杭大运河提供了前提条件。这是因为淮河的径流量虽然要比黄河小一些，但是在漫长的时间中，淮河的河道相当固定，且淮河本身携带泥沙量小，因此淮河的河床被冲刷得比较深，当黄河的水量注入之后距离河面就更深了。在这种条件下，大运河自然就可以穿过黄河而不影响漕运。这就是为什么尽管黄河南流会给两岸百姓带来巨大的灾难，但是朝廷却一直以之为益处，唯恐黄河重新向北流。事实上，我们必须指出，只要不对其存在构成威胁，官僚国家是绝对不在乎离首都千里之外百姓的死活的，黄河南流的确可能加剧了直隶和山东的旱情，使黄淮沿岸的百姓年年生活在死亡的威胁下，但是这和北京的皇帝和官僚们有什么关系呢？在他们眼中，几百万百姓的死活怎么可能比运往北京的钱粮更重要。如果我们对于明清时期的史料进行检索，就不难注意到当出现黄淮泛滥的记录时，漕运的重要性远远排在百姓死活前面，在很多情况下只有“坏漕渠”的记录，百姓受到了何等损失是完全没有记录的。

如果人们对于中华帝国在治理黄河上采取的态度有所疑问，我的建议是直接阅读《明史》卷五十九和卷六十，这两部分就属于黄河志，朝廷采取何种的利益考量在其中表现得明明白白。例如卷五十九中河南御史涂升的进言说得非常清楚，“黄河为患，南决病河南，北决病山东。昔汉决酸枣，复决瓠子；宋决馆陶，复决澶州；元决汴梁，复决蒲口。然汉都关中，宋都大梁，河决为患，不过濒河数郡而已。今京师专藉会通河岁漕粟数百万石，河决而

北，则大为漕忧。”黄河无论是南决还是北决，死上多少老百姓都是区区小事，当务之急是不能让黄河北流，那样漕运就成为问题了。黄河北流对于河道稳定有利，对于天下百姓有利，这一点在中国从来都不是秘密，统治者和高级知识分子对此心知肚明。清前期的经学家、地理学家胡渭在其著作《禹贡锥指》卷十三下中记载了元代官员余阙的评论（余阙曰：南方之地本高于北，河之南徙难而北徙易…奚必岁岁劳费防其北决邪？），要知道那个时候京杭大运河贯通总共也没几年。甚至在中国向来以信息质量差而著称的百度百科竟然也直截了当地承认，所谓元明清的水患根本上就是一场持续了六个世纪的政治灾难，而非能够推诿为天灾。在负责河务的官员们看来，两岸百姓比起漕运来说自然不值一提，例如明代治水名臣潘季驯曾说“是淮病而黄病，黄病而漕亦病，相因之势也。”而对“百姓之病”便不提了。完全不能怪潘季驯这么说，中国人总是莫名其妙地对所谓的贤臣能臣有一种滤镜，但事实上，只要是官僚其权力都来源于上级，所以他们必然要对上级负责，在这一点上严嵩和海瑞不会有任何差别。拿捏河务官员命运的是皇帝，而不是两岸的百姓，所以他们就只能把皇帝所依赖的漕运放到两岸百姓的生死前面。

一个让外国人可能感到非常震惊的事实是，尽管我国在官方层面上反复鼓吹大运河的“伟大意义”，在全国修建了许多以大运河为主题的博物馆，还有以大运河景观为核心的5A 级景区。甚至在 2014 年，大运河还被成功申请成为联合国教科文组织认证的世界文化遗产。然而，即使是在今天的中国大陆，大运河作为一条血泪之河的残酷本质也并非秘密。不但作为正史的《元史》、《明史》都可以被公开查阅，而且涉及到中国水利史，并直接指出中华帝国晚期的黄河水患主要是人为政治灾难的重要学术著作，例如上个世纪中国历史学家岑仲勉所著的《黄河变迁史》也并非禁书。2022 年大陆拍摄的歌颂清朝康熙年间治理水患功绩的电视剧《天下长河》有一个耐人寻味的镜头：康熙皇帝看向墙上所贴的三张纸，每张纸上都写一个让皇帝忧心忡忡的国务。中间的纸上写着“漕运”，左侧的纸上写着“河务”，右侧的纸上写着“三藩”。这三张纸所排列的顺序便反映了在康熙皇帝眼中三件事的重要程度。它更加戏剧性地暗示了一点：当帝国总是把漕运的优先级放在河务之上，那么让黄河河清海晏就是永远不可能的。我们无法得知这个镜头是否是电视剧的导演和编剧有意为之，但是这显而易见的反映出一点，那就是即使在今天，中国的知识分子中清楚中华帝国晚期所谓“治理黄河”本质的大有人在。

因此认为水患治理的需要是国家加强官僚体制的推动因素属于完全因果颠倒的说法，我们应该直截了当地指出，恰恰是官僚国家的草菅人命、唯上是从、腐败无能和好大喜功才使得中华大地上的各种所谓的“自然灾害”被人为地扩大了，1975 年的板桥水库溃决就是一个比较近的典型例子。因此就绝无“水利缔造帝国”这种说法，恰恰是为了维系已经存在的复辟官僚帝国，整个中国社会才不得不在水利上追加如此惊人的投入，并白白付出这么多牺牲。说回黄河，十分讽刺的是，由于黄河的含泥沙量实在巨大，实际上在中国被迫开国的前

夜即使是淮河的河床也已经被泥沙沉积而大幅抬高。到了清代，人们为了能够让大运河上的船只正常地穿过黄河，不得不在两者交界处修建越来越复杂的辅助河道，在地图上看活像一个搭满了支架的心脏一般。饶是如此依旧是治标不治本，到乾隆朝末期南流的黄河阻塞运河航运也只不过是一个时间问题了，反倒是西方的坚船利炮带来的科学技术使得中国人终于从“运河监狱”中解放出来。中华帝国晚期的所谓水利事业，本质上就是这样一个陷入绝境的泥足巨人日复一日挣扎着走向灭亡的缩影，整个体制不惜让人民付出任何牺牲，只为在原有的轨道上能安稳数日，但是最终仍然难保长久直至灭亡。人们如果思考这样一个假设，也就是如果中国一直不与西方发生接触，那么清朝末期在北方生态接近崩溃和运河完全失去作用的情况下会走向何方，北京还可能继续作为专制帝国的首都吗？我想这个答案会十分有趣。

第三，还是之前所强调的，如果没有官僚国家的压制，那么中国的封建化进程当然不可能只停留在初级阶段而是会一直发展下去，因此我们不能假设封建化的中国一直只有中世纪早期的公共工程建设能力。从欧洲的情况来看，从中世纪盛期开始封建国家已经有建设大型公共工程的能力，即使从水利工程来说，也有荷兰地区从十世纪开始大量修建海堤这样的例子。而封建时期结束之后的近世社会所能调动的力量更为强大，在全世界范围内最有代表性的例子大概就是德川幕府的江户建设，幕府彻底治理了关东平原上肆虐的河流，并且仅仅花了一个世纪的时间就使得江户一跃成为全世界最大的城市，这样的成绩还是在一个闭关锁国的狭长岛国取得的。同时期绝对主义的欧洲同样处于水利工程如火如荼开展的时期，大量运河的建成就是强有力的证明。如果中国的封建化正常继续下去，那么就从我国封建化开始较早的情况来估计（在东汉末年封建化的趋势就已经很明显了），最晚到本位面的元朝时期封建中国就已经结束了典型的封建阶级社会开始转型为近世国家，现在的京杭大运河也就修建于元朝。因此我们完全有理由相信经历了封建化进程的近世中国想要修建元明清时期的京杭大运河，那它也绝对不是没有力量做到这一点的，甚至完全可以做得更好。

第四，就算在水患治理和水利工程上具有很大的建设需求，到底会不会产生像中国这样稳固的官僚秩序也是一个问题。在比中国更靠南的热带地区没有像中国中原地区这样相对分明的四季而只有水季和旱季的区分，水灾和旱灾的表现更加极端，没有理由认为这些地区进行大型公共水利设施的需求就比中国小。例如我们可以很清楚地指出处于古典时期的高棉帝国显然就极端依赖于水利工程，这从吴哥附近的大型蓄水池数量来看是很明显的。但是高棉的神王是通过将水利建设融入一种大型宗教建筑群所营造的神圣氛围当中来完成，至于高棉本身的古典官僚体制实在是弱得可怜，这个帝国连像样的继承法都没有，总共二十六个神王只有八个是继承兄弟或者父亲的帝位。中世纪印度在进行大型水利建设时同样倚仗宗教的力量，印度各地广泛存在的宏伟阶梯井就是有力的证明，阶梯井从实用的角度来说虽然是用来在旱季储存水源，但是它巨大的规模和精湛的雕刻艺术所表达出的宗教氛围无疑会使信徒倾倒。在欧亚大陆广大的伊斯兰世界，干旱或者半干旱的环境是生活的常态，当地农业对灌溉

的依赖程度显然是中国长城以内年均降水量400毫米以上的区域根本比不了的。但是人们显然可以看出，就算中世纪的穆斯林君主要比欧洲的同行们明显专制，然而和中国的皇帝相比简直就是小巫见大巫。这是因为伊斯兰社会通过教士阶层在各个居住地以清真寺为中心完成了社会组织，教士在水利设施修建和维护，水资源分配和使用上起到了领导和仲裁作用，并通过发挥这种作用反过来进一步巩固了其社会地位，因而，整个社会根本不需要一个多么强大的官僚体制。如果人们注意到现在被政教合一的神权政府统治的伊朗，它正是一个整体上十分干旱的，拥有极其悠久灌溉农业历史的，现在信仰伊斯兰教的文明古国。所以经过这样的观察我们不难得出一个结论，就算古典时期到中世纪的某个政权乃至文明具有非常强烈地进行大型公共水利设施的现实需要，它的反应大概率也是向宗教寻求帮助（当然这不排除它在政治上有集权化的需求，只不过中国以外的历史表明封建政权与宗教和宗教组织合作足以胜任那个年代水利工程建设和维护的需要）。如果我们回忆汉武帝当年面对严重水灾时的反应，就很容易想起即使是那个年代的中华帝国也依赖宗教的帮助，无论是指望方士的法术可以平息水患，还是在黄河决口处起宫殿镇压灾厄在本质上都是宗教行为。只不过汉帝国强大的国家能力使得在采取具体行动解决水患的时候不再那么需要宗教进行号召而已（但也不是完全不需要，例如汉武帝亲自前往瓠子指挥堵塞黄河决口前他刚刚完成一次泰山封禅返回，这本身就形成了一种宗教氛围）。

况且在中国之外的地区，人们确实能够指出一些专制集权程度很高的古代政权确实曾在政府的意志和组织下进行了大规模的水利工程建设，例如古埃及和印加帝国。但是仔细一想就会发现这些政权本质上非常倚仗宗教的感召力，法老不但自己就具有神性而且也与祭司合作，印加皇室干脆自称是太阳神的后裔。我们应当指出“去宗教化”本身就是官僚复辟以来中华帝国的一个显著特征，这一点从中国内地的宗教组织衰落，政权合法性来源发生变化等各种社会的方方面面都得到了反映。宗教在社会构建中起到的影响急剧下降，这个事实原本就是学界所谓“唐宋变革”中非常重要的一个截面，是复辟官僚国家形成和巩固过程中带来的必然结果。中华帝国复辟的官僚体制是极为憎恨宗教与其争夺地方控制权的，要不然也就没有三武一宗灭佛了。因此具有较大的建设大型公共水利设施的需求与形成并维持强有力的官僚体制之间在封建生产关系作为主流的时间段内难说有强因果关系，这个理论是荒谬的。

就这样，我居然用了这么大的篇幅才完成我一开始以为只需要稍加解释就大功告成的事项。不过写得多有写得多的好处，我已经彻底反驳了目前学界为中国复辟时期官僚制度所辩护的最主要的两个理论，至于剩下的就已经不值一驳了。写得详细一点也是应该的，只要能把这个肆虐了十四个世纪的恶魔彻底钉死在棺材里。